



Brookline

BROOKLINE COUNCIL ON AGING · BROOKLINE SENIOR CENTER

Aging in the Town of Brookline: A Community Needs Assessment — Executive Summary, July 2026

WHO WE ARE

Brookline's older adults, by the numbers

Brookline's population age 60 and older is sizeable and expected to keep growing. Based on U.S. Census data, the American Community Survey (2024), and UMass Donahue Institute projections.



21%

of Brookline's 63,266 residents are age 60+ (13,222 residents)



42%

of residents age 80+ live alone (vs. 25% of those in their 60s)



39%

of residents age 75+ report at least one disability

NOW VS. 2040

A growing older population

TODAY

13,222

residents age 60+ (2020, up from 10,816 in 2010)

21% of all residents



BY 2040

14,975+

residents age 60+ projected

24% of all residents

A larger older population means rising demand for the programs, services, and supports that help residents stay independent and connected to their community.

FINANCIAL PRESSURES

Financial insecurity & housing expenses

Financial insecurity, driven largely by taxes, is among the top concerns for older residents.

HOUSING COST BURDEN

50%

of renters age 65+ spend 30% or more of income on housing — the highest rate of any age group

- 37% of respondents wrote in about cost-of-living concerns — home maintenance, taxes, and utilities
- Stakeholders described many residents as "house rich but tax poor," warning longtime residents may be priced out

MEETING BASIC NEEDS

20%

lacked the finances for at least one basic necessity in the past 12 months

\$57,500

median income for women living alone — older adults living alone have substantially lower incomes

HOME REPAIRS

45%

need home repairs to safely remain in their homes over the next five years

14%

of those needing repairs said they could not afford them

"Taxes are crushing us; cannot keep up with increases; falling behind on paying for services (water, trash, electric, heat expenses)"

— Brookline survey respondent

SOCIAL CONNECTION

Social wellness & isolation

Older adults who live alone may especially benefit from programs and services that offer opportunities to connect in person.



42%

of respondents age 80+ live alone (vs. 25% of those in their 60s)



19%

reported some form of exclusion — 33% of them cited age as the reason



37.8%

depression rate among Brookline older adults, higher than the state (34.6%)

"Isolation. Since I live alone in my own house. Neighbors tend to be younger with busy lives. Older friends/neighbors are moving away, getting sick/dementia, etc. Can create 'loneliness'. Which makes having a great + accessible Senior Center so important."

— Brookline survey respondent

CAREGIVING

The strain on family caregivers

Older residents experience changing physical and psychological conditions, and caregivers to older adults need help managing this care.



41%

of respondents provided care or assistance to a disabled or frail person in the past 5 years



50%

of caregivers are ages 60–69 — the largest share of any cohort, suggesting many are part of the "sandwich" generation



57%

of caregivers found it somewhat or very challenging to balance with other responsibilities

*Approximately **1 in 5** caregivers reported declines in their physical health, mental health, or social life due to caregiving.*

TRANSPORTATION & ACCESSIBILITY

Getting around & staying mobile

Focus group participants repeatedly identified medical transportation as a core service that supports independence and aging in place — and voiced concern about reductions in it.



16%

of non-driving respondents missed, cancelled, or rescheduled a medical appointment because of transportation barriers



Nearly half

of respondents reported at least one transportation challenge

When asked, residents identified the following barriers:

- Reductions in medical transportation services
- Not enough subsidized rideshare or medical-transport rides
- Unsafe sidewalks and winter conditions
- Homes and community spaces that are hard to navigate with walkers or wheelchairs

SENIOR CENTER

An invaluable resource — at capacity

Residents want the Brookline Senior Center to keep expanding options for participation, but its capacity to serve the diverse needs of older residents is limited — and many residents have not yet been reached.

HAVE ATTENDED THE SENIOR CENTER

34% attended

66% not yet reached

NOT YET REACHED

34% of survey respondents have attended the Senior Center; participation is more common among older residents.

66%

of survey respondents have not yet attended the Senior Center

55%

of non-attendees said more knowledge about programs and services would make them more likely to participate — the most commonly cited factor

35% of monthly attendees say more parking would boost participation

32% of occasional attendees say the same

37% want more weekend programming

- Opened in 2001, when about 9,028 residents were age 60+ — compared with about 13,347 residents age 60+ in 2024.

- Strong interest in expanded educational, cultural, and wellness programming, pointing to demand for more space.

"Senior center is too small for the number of elderly who live in Brookline... Space is inadequate. A much larger building is needed with parking!"

— Brookline survey respondent

STRATEGIC RECOMMENDATIONS

What the report recommends

These are the strategic recommendations set out in the report itself. It encourages Brookline to actively expand its community efforts to address the needs of the town's aging population.



Financial security & tax relief

Continue reviewing and expanding existing property-tax relief programs to help older homeowners remain in their homes.



Outreach & in-home supports for 80+

Prioritize outreach and in-home supports for adults ages 80 and older, particularly those living alone or without nearby family support.



Support for family caregivers

Expand support for family caregivers and identify pathways to reach "younger older adults" who would benefit from caregiving support.



Transportation to healthcare

Prioritize the restoration and expansion of transportation services that help older adults access healthcare appointments.



Accessibility & Age-Friendly review

Conduct an accessibility review of municipal facilities, destinations, and public spaces, and continue to incorporate Age-Friendly principles across all departments and boards.



Long-term facilities strategy

Develop a long-term facilities strategy for the Senior Center — including renovation, expansion, or alternative and satellite service-delivery models — so more residents can be served.



Coordinated communications hub

Reposition the Senior Center as a central hub for information, engagement, and community connection through a coordinated communications strategy using print, digital, and telephone.

"I'm sure you all are doing excellent work but for folks like me who do not need or access your offerings you need to publicize your programs so that they reach folks like me."

— Brookline survey respondent

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Commissioned by the Town of Brookline, Brookline Council on Aging, and Brookline Senior Center. Produced by the **Center for Social & Demographic Research on Aging**, Gerontology Institute, University of Massachusetts Boston.

For more information and the full report, visit brooklineseniorcenter.org · Community Survey: 2,259 respondents (17% response rate) · 7 key informant interviews · 4 focus groups (41 participants).